

Qualifications of an Elder:
An Exposition of “Not a Lover of Money”

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Introduction

This paper will examine what it means to be “not a lover of money.” The answer is essentially to love God rather than money, and to work hard to make money because he wants to “do all things for Christ” rather than be selfish and store up storehouses for himself (parable of Jesus). We see that religion serves as good business education to be moral, and that this religion is valid in society. Good religion generates good money and good society.

What does it mean to “not be a lover of money?” (1 Timothy 3:1-7). I believe there are several meanings to this. First, it means that he shuns money. Just as justification by faith, according to Luther, shuns human righteousness, the elder who does not love money shuns away the god called mammon. He actively and completely kicks out any desire for money at all because desire is usually of human origin; and rather than seek for money and worry about it, he trusts that God will supply all his needs according to Christ Jesus (Philippians).

Second, it means that he gives money. He gives money generously to all who need it and to different ministries. He is not stingy. He is not hanging onto his money and trying to save up. He is not trying to be selfish and worry about having enough for tomorrow. He freely gives. He trusts that God will supply all his needs, so he not only does not love money, he gives it away.

Third, instead of placing money as the central focus of his ministry at church as an elder, he places the concerns of God first. As Jesus says in Matthew on the Sermon on the Mount, life consists more than food and water and money - it consists of the matters of God, such as life, meaning, significance, honor, glory, worship, love, and care. It is the matters of God that concerns the elder, rather than money and metrics.

Metrics are a way of measuring things. Money is a way of measuring value and worth in this world. If it's worth a lot of money, it means it's valuable and worth something. But money is just a metric - and true value is hidden beneath the surface and may not be measured correctly.

And so the elder uses correct metrics, and measures correctly. He judges all things because he is a spiritual man (Corinthians), and he measures by God's judgment and principles and by the Word of God.

The thesis of this paper is that: elders must wisely use money by loving God rather than loving money. They must work hard to generate money because they love God, and seek to give money rather than receive. They trust God that God will provide for their needs and the money they need, rather than seeking for it. These qualities, abounding more and more, is what makes a good elder to be “not a lover of money.”

Labour Is Holy, but Business is Dangerous

The first source¹ talks about the history of business as Christians (entrepreneurship) in the West, and how secular businesses emerged, and the perspective of the Christians toward business and labour.

From the title of the paper, it seems to distinguish working for the Lord (labour) and working for money (business). This is exactly the tension we face in this world. We need to survive, we need to make money, but what is our motive and our goal? Is it to make money or is it to serve God? Is it to survive or is it out of love for others?

This question of motive or telos is the question that the book of Job is about. Job was the most wealthiest and blessed person in all the world. And Satan claimed that it was the money and the blessing that Job wanted, and that if you take that way, Job would turn from God.

And so, we are faced with the same question: will we turn from God if all our money and blessing is taken away from us? Are we lovers of money or lovers of God?

According to the paper, the ancient world had a “hostility to personal enrichment, new knowledge and technological innovation were also perceived as highly threatening to established

¹ Sarah Drakopoulou Dodd and George Gotsis, “*Labour Is Holy but Business Is Dangerous: Enterprise Values From the Church Fathers to the Reformation*,” *Journal of Enterprising Culture* **15**, no. 2 (2007): 133-63, <https://doi.org/10.1142/S0218495807000083>

orders.” This is interesting because some philosophers and regular people would say that computers and new technology is a good thing - YouTube is good. But the ancient world and ancient Christians were always wary of new technologies and ventures.

The entrepreneur, in the ancient world, was viewed controversially because “he challenges the status quo, brings disruptive change, sees things in a way others cannot, and pursues his venture vision at the expense of other goals.”

So many people on the news and on social media these days praise those who bring “disruptive” changes to the market and to business. Not so with the ancients. The ancients knew that technology can bring us further from God, and progression is not progression at all - it is getting further from the origin of God.

Therefore, what is the perspective that elders should take on money? Elders and the church will receive tithes and offerings from businessmen and from people who work. Also, the elders themselves probably work at businesses and generate tithe and offerings.

How should we view this money and view work? Is it actually true that “disruptive” changes are bad, according to the ancients?

And my perspective is that the truth will always be the same, but will have to be expressed in the modern culture in the modern context. And therefore, in any age, there will be human beings doing business, living in the world and society and amidst technology, and the truth has to be proclaimed in that context, but never become tainted by the world.

This is in regards to the Word, but in regards to money, we must do the Will of God and Work of God in Serving Others and Labor, and this will be the source of our business and money.

This can be disruptive or not, but will always be love and the work of God for others. This core is what should generate money for the Christian and for the church.

As a side note, if there is unclean money, for example, blood money that enters the church offering, what should we do? We should refuse it. The church should labor honestly and bring offerings that are clean money. But of course, we have blood on our hands - we've eaten chicken and beef and killed those poor animals to eat its flesh and fry it.

The church has to do its best to purify the money and forgive sins through Jesus Christ.

Love of God will Produce Money

The next source² shows statistics on the link between religion and entrepreneurship - if religion causes more or less businesses to flourish, and their investment into knowledge.

“The idea that religion—the sets of beliefs, activities and institutions based on faith in supernatural forces (Stark and Bainbridge 1985)—is linked to entrepreneurship is hardly novel. Weber’s (1930) seminal work on the *Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* laid the foundation to understand the mechanisms of how religion, an arguably personal attribute, can become prevalent in society and affect societal members.”

According to this, Weber stated in 1930 that religion can affect the wealth of society. This can be “basically suggesting that religion ‘supports’ business.”

“For instance, Noble (2013: 5) notes “Perhaps nowhere is the intimate connection between religion and technology more manifest than in the USA, where an unrivaled popular enchantment with technological advance is matched by an equally earnest popular expectation of Jesus Christ’s return.”

² K. Praveen Parboteeah, Sascha G. Walter, and Jörn H. Block, “When Does Christian Religion Matter for Entrepreneurial Activity? The Contingent Effect of a Country’s Investments into Knowledge,” *Journal of Business Ethics* **130**, no. 2 (2015): 447–65, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-014-2239-z>

The USA is possibly the most religious country in the world, and the author is hinting that its religiosity is directly related to its “technological advance.”

And from this we can conclude that the love of God will produce money. When we love God and are driven by a strong work-ethic to do all things for Christ and to work heartily, it produces a work environment and society that generates the most money.

In theology, we can explain this as, the more dedicated we are at laboring for God, the more God will provide money for those who labor. He rewards them, and uses Just Balances. Therefore, God will help those who help themselves, in some sense.

This is the characteristic of the elder who labors. He should labor to serve God and therefore, be well-respected in society (another attribute of an elder) because he is well-respected in the workplace because he has lots of knowledge and skills and capability to do work and generate revenue.

A Christian who knows how to generate large revenue and has incredibly valuable skills for society is well-respected in society, and is favored by God. This is the wisdom of Daniel in the Bible, and of Joseph in Genesis. It is also of Paul the Apostle, who was very intelligent at his time.

Christianity is Good Morality for Entrepreneurship

The third source³ talks of how teaching religion, such as Christianity, may play a big role in making entrepreneurs moral. It says that for teaching entrepreneurs, finding an “educational approach has become a huge challenge among scholars.” It seems that that “both the social and

³ Crispen Karanda and Nuria Toledano, “Morality, Religious Writings, and Entrepreneurship Education: An Integrative Proposal Using the Example of Christian Narratives,” *Journal of Moral Education* 46, no. 2 (2017): 195–211, <https://doi.org/10.1080/03057240.2016.1238819>

moral side of entrepreneurship have gained prominence in the general discourse of academics and educators.” However, the debate shows that religion is also finding a place in the role of education.

And my perspective on all of this is this: there is an onion with layers and there is a core to the issues and matter. If we look at the surface, we see the layers of the onion - this includes the surface things, such as the news and the behavior of people in society.

But we all know the symptoms are just the outer layer of the onion, and that if we truly want to change a person for the better, we need to look at the core of the matter - the core of the onion, for instance.

And in this debate, of morality and social impact and religion as a basis for good behavior in entrepreneurship, we see the model of an onion exactly. Social concerns will always be a good thing, but how do we actually make society good? And how do we define good? And how can we be moral if we don’t have a definition of good? And what is the core of all this behavior? Is there a spirit that drives us? Is there a God who created good and evil? These fundamental questions of theology and philosophy drive us, and we will always be driven back to the question: is Christianity the correct worldview?

And so the entrepreneurs and to the educators, I ask, “Who is Jesus Christ and do you follow him and Christianity? What is your religion? What is your philosophy? What is your morality? And what is your social concerns?” And, of course, this is going from most essential core issues, to outer behavioral questions.

How an Elder Spends his Money

The fourth source⁴ speaks of developing frameworks that decide how we make decisions in business - essentially, our moral reasoning. The paper says that religion is intertwined in our daily life, so as to influence our decision-making and our moral reasoning. In essence, they are “sets of practices effectively intertwined with many aspects of everyday economic life.” And so, we see that Christ has to be the center of how we spend our money on a daily-basis. How an elder spends his money, is a good indication of whether he is a “lover of money,” or a Theophilus.

It says that “religion may indeed serve to foster certain entrepreneurial pursuits.” And I can see why because Bible-making is a business that generates good income, for example. Also, religion can drive people to be dedicated to social causes that drive businesses that try to help people. Essentially, the Love of God drives good business and money-making.

Conclusion

In conclusion, we see that elders should love God and not money. By loving God, we hate mammon, and we trust that God will give us money, rather than us seeking for money. Elders should seek to give money, and work hard to generate money, rather than be selfish. And it is this love of God that produces money.

⁴ Sarah Drakopoulou Dodd and George Gotsis, “The Interrelationships between Entrepreneurship and Religion,” *International Journal of Entrepreneurship and Innovation* 8, no. 2 (2007): 93–104, <https://doi.org/10.5367/000000007780808066>

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